Politics: An Introduction

Macharia Barii

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The Ledger We All Live On

Every society runs on an unspoken ledger.

Every day, people give and take. We go to work and give our labor in exchange for wages. We care for family members, and in turn, are cared for. We pay taxes, and expect roads, water, schools, and a measure of protection. We follow laws, and expect that those laws will be applied fairly. These are all relationships of reciprocity.

The question is always the same: who gets what, who owes what, who can leave, and who gets a say?

This set of give-and-take relationships, with all of their rules, expectations, and unspoken understandings, is what we call the ledger. Civilization is nothing more than the web of these relationships held together by institutions. The ledger is the structure underneath it all. It determines the shape of our lives far more than we often realize.

Politics is the Contest Over the Ledger

Politics is, at its core, the struggle over the terms of that ledger.

It is not just about elections, though elections are one part of it. It is about wages and rent. It is about who is expected to do unpaid care work. It is about the cost of leaving a bad job, an abusive home, or a crumbling town. It is about whether people can organize to demand better, or if doing so is punished. It is about whether the rules bend for some and break for others.

Whenever people argue over any of these things and try to change them, that is politics. Whenever a group tries to defend the way things are because it benefits them, that is also politics. The fight is never "is there politics?", it is "who gets to set the terms?"

Governance, Government, and Who Actually Rules

To understand this fight, we need to distinguish three things that are constantly confused: politics, governance, and government.

- **Politics** is the contest. It is people fighting over shares, burdens, the cost of leaving, and the ability to have a say.
- **Governance** is the maintenance. It is all of the things that keep the ledger running as it is. Enforcement, courts, rules, norms, even community pressure, all count as governance. Many things govern us that have nothing to do with a parliament. Markets govern through prices. Religions govern through norms. Families govern through obligation.
- **Government** is the specialized apparatus that does a lot of that governing. The bureaucracy, the legislature, the courts, the police, and the military are all parts of it. It is one governor among many, not the only one.

The most important distinction of all, however, is between three groups that are almost always conflated.

There is the **coalition** (the funders and sustainers). These are the actors that materially fund, organize, and keep the government in power. They are almost always a narrow group.

There is the **electorate** (the voters). These are those legally able to vote. Elections grant formal legitimacy, but votes do not automatically translate to influence.

There is the **constituency** (those claimed to be represented). This is whoever a politician says they are fighting for. It could be "the working class", "the nation", or "the people". The constituency is often far larger than the coalition, and in many places, is vastly underrepresented by it.

The government will always serve someone. The question is: does it serve the coalition, or does it serve its constituency? More often than not, the gap between the two is the gap between rhetoric and reality.

Voice, Exit, and Loyalty

When people are unhappy with their place on the ledger, they have three broad options: voice, exit, or loyalty.

- **Voice** is fighting to change things from within. It is organizing a union, protesting, writing to representatives, or demanding better terms.
- **Exit** is walking away. Quitting a job, moving towns, or leaving a relationship. Exit only works if leaving is actually viable. If leaving means destitution, homelessness, or losing your entire support system, the cost is too high to be a real option.
- **Loyalty** is staying and putting up with it. Sometimes this comes from genuine love or duty. Other times, it is born out of desperation, fear, or the belief that there is simply no other choice.

For a healthy society, voice must be credible and exit must be viable. When both are open, people can negotiate. When both are foreclosed, people are left with only loyalty. And loyalty, when stretched far enough, always runs out.

The Four Freedoms and Why They Matter For Democracy

Democracy is not just about counting votes. At its heart, democracy is the attempt to let people collectively renegotiate the terms of the ledger through peaceful means. For that to be possible, certain conditions must exist. This is exactly what Franklin D. Roosevelt was getting at with his Four Freedoms.

1. **Freedom of speech and expression** — People must be able to say what is wrong. If criticizing those in power is too dangerous, the problems on the ledger stay hidden and go uncorrected.
2. **Freedom of worship** — People must be able to follow their conscience. This matters because it gives people a source of obligation and legitimacy outside of the government itself. A person can say, "this law is unjust", not just because it hurts them, but because their morals demand better.
3. **Freedom from want** — People must have their basic needs met. If someone is one rent payment away from being evicted, they cannot freely bargain. Desperation makes voice timid and exit impossible. Material security is what gives people the breathing room to fight for better terms.

4. **Freedom from fear** — People must be able to organize without being watched, harassed, or punished for it. Without this freedom, fear does the government's job for it. It silences people before they ever speak up.

These four freedoms are the pressure valves of a democracy. They keep the ledger open to change without people having to resort to violence to be heard. When any of these freedoms begin to erode, democracy becomes hollow. The votes may remain, but the ability to actually contest the terms of the ledger is gone. Power simply becomes more insulated from the people it is supposed to represent.

When Voice is Suppressed: The Path To Underground Movements and Explosion

The moment that voice becomes too costly to exercise openly, something shifts. Grievances do not disappear. They go underground.

People begin whispering to trusted friends what they could not say in public. They realize they are not alone in their struggles. From there comes mutual aid, hidden networks of support, and eventually, clandestine organization. A hidden transcript forms. Entire communities learn to care for each other outside of the institutions that have failed them, whilst building an alternative vision of how things could be.

For a time, from the outside, everything looks calm. The government mistakes this silence for approval. It sees no protests, so it assumes all is well. In reality, pressure is building.

Repression only makes this worse. Every time someone is punished for speaking up, it confirms to others that the system is exactly as unjust as they suspected. Every act of brutality breeds more solidarity. Every broken promise adds fuel to the fire.

Eventually, a spark comes. It could be a blatant act of corruption, a brutal crackdown on an otherwise peaceful protest, or an economic shock that finally makes life unbearable for those who have been scraping by for years. All at once, the dam breaks. The things people have only ever dared to say behind closed doors come pouring into the streets.

This is why suppressing voice so often leads to protests, revolutions, civil wars, or wider conflict. It is not that oppressed people suddenly become violent out of nowhere. It is that they have been trying to speak for years, and nobody listened until the cost of staying quiet became greater than the cost of rising up. The longer a system refuses to hear people politically, the more likely it is that they will be forced to make themselves heard by other means.

Religion, Ideology, and Legitimacy in Non-Democratic Systems

Not every system relies on repression alone to stay in power. Many rely on legitimacy. And one of the oldest tools for securing that legitimacy is belief.

In non-democratic systems, religion or ideology is often used to buy consent for an unequal ledger. There are a few ways this works.

First, it can **naturalize** the existing order. If hierarchy is presented as God's will, as the natural order of things, or as an inevitable law of history, then questioning it becomes not just political disobedience, but sacrilege or treason. Inequality stops looking like a choice, and starts looking like fate.

Second, it can **redirect blame**. Instead of pointing to the coalition that benefits from the system, people are told to blame outsiders, heretics, immigrants, or enemies. This fractures solidarity between groups that would otherwise have a great deal in common.

Third, it can **offer meaning in exchange for loyalty**. A system that cannot guarantee freedom from want can still promise honor, glory, salvation, or a place in a glorious future. For those with nothing to lose materially, these promises can be powerful. For those desperate enough, loyalty becomes a trade: endure now, be rewarded later.

Finally, it can **fuse power with the sacred**. When the altar and the throne become one, dissent is no longer just criticism of policy. It is an attack on the sacred order itself. This raises the cost of voice astronomically. It also corrupts both sides. Power uses faith to shield itself, and faith is used by power to shield its own interests.

This is the key difference. In a healthy democratic system, faith can exist independently and act as a check on power, holding leaders to a higher moral standard. When faith is captured by the coalition, however, it becomes an instrument of that coalition. Instead of calling power to account, it justifies power no matter what it does.

Ideologies can do the exact same thing. Nationalism, revolutionary rhetoric, or the promise of a "pure" society can all be wielded to sanctify an unequal ledger, demand blind loyalty, and crush dissent in the name of a greater good.

The Choice

At the end of the day, politics comes down to a choice between two approaches to an unequal ledger.

The first is to keep the pressure valves open. Listen early. Allow people to organize. Guarantee the four freedoms. Make exit viable and voice credible. Accept that conflict is normal, and negotiate over the terms of the ledger instead of criminalizing the people fighting over it.

The second is to weld those valves shut. Suppress voice, manufacture loyalty through fear or faith, serve the coalition, and call it "stability". This approach can appear peaceful for a time. It almost never stays that way.

Stability built on consent is durable. Stability built on silence is borrowed. And eventually, the bill always comes due.

The question every society must answer, again and again, is simple: will we renegotiate the ledger politically, or will we be forced to fight over it?